

3.1 The Contenders

3.1.1 Prerequisites

Most sites use Flash or JavaScript to power their interfaces. So, in order to enable the services, the browser should be JavaScript-enabled with a Flash plugin installed. Those of you familiar with either JavaScript or Flash would fervently vouch for the importance of having a broadband Internet connection, since the interfaces can be really heavy. While not a prerequisite, having a fast connection considerably reduces the waiting time. Additionally, some of the effects available on these sites are quite computing-intensive, and having a powerful PC yields faster results.

3.1.2 Picnik.com



Editing pictures using the Picnik tab

This is a Flash-based site. A 1.5-MB flash file is first downloaded to your system prior to using the service. There are two versions of the service, with the paid premium version offering some additional effects. However, the free service is sufficient in most aspects for basic users. While one can register on the site, using the services does not require one to do so.

Picnik integrates with most online photo sharing sites like Flickr, Webshots and Photobucket. Images already uploaded to these sites can be directly edited in Picnik, after logging in into the site with the username and password of the respective image hosting site. Photos on your system can also be edited, after they have been uploaded. You can even load an image onto Picnik by providing the URL of an online image. A Picnik add-on for Firefox is also available, which adds an option in the context menu that makes it easier to import images to Picnik for editing.

The interface is relatively easy to use even for amateurs at image editing. A tool tip pops up every time a tool is selected, offering helpful instructions on usage. Most popular images formats such as JPG,